members of the former Socialist Working-Class Youth, the Socialist Youth League, the free-trade union groups and the Hitler Youth. Ostensibly, Honecker's mission was to receive underground literature (often printed on frail onionskin sheets) from neighbouring states to distribute throughout Berlin. With Baum's help, he found modest lodgings on Brusseler Straße and, still relatively lean and fit, was able to make covert handovers of clandestine material and even smuggle a small printing press into the heart of the Nazi capital. His situation was not enviable. Money was a real problem, and as Berlin swarmed with Gestapo, police kept watch on interminable working-class districts such as Wedding, while all suspicious post was seized.

Although careless risks were frequent, overconfidence led to his luck running out on 3 December after a rendezvous on Solinger Straße near the Tiergarten with Sarah Fodorovä, a pretty young Czech girl. Fodorovä had been duped by a friend into delivering a suitcase, unaware that it was stuffed with communist literature, such as the Rote Fahne and the Moscow paper Deutscher Zentral Zeitung, hidden under a false bottom. She did, however, manage to deposit the case at the Anhalter railway station luggage office and slipped the ticket to Erich. Later that night, he set about retrieving the suitcase. 'While I waited, I saw that the station officer was disturbed about something when he went with the luggage ticket towards the suitcase and compared the numbers,' he said, describing the experience. 'He vanished quickly. I saw two men come near me and immediately thought, caught!' In a desperate attempt to save his skin, he grabbed the case, dashed to the taxi rank, and told a waiting driver to stomp on the gas. After a few minutes – with his wits still intact – Honecker was back on foot running alongside Zoologischer Garten station before vanishing into the neighbouring Tiergarten. But his luck ran out. After receiving a tip-off, gun-toting Gestapo officers burst into Honecker's apartment the next morning, he was not treated gently. All too carelessly, he had left a stash of propaganda leaflets and literature hidden throughout his flat. Erich Honecker was about to gain his sobering introduction to Nazi justice.